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A CONTEMPORARY MORALIST: ALBERT CAMUS

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I

I USE the word Moralist, somewhat after the French fashion, in the sense of a commentator on the human scene. I apologize for Contemporary, but there was another Camus, way back in the seventeenth century, who is being resuscitated now and who, according to the new *Encyclopaedia of Literature*, "wrote besides theological works some fifty novels which make him a pioneer of religious edification through popular fiction." Our Camus is very much of our century and is still a comparatively young man. And he is contemporary not only in the accidental sense that he happens to be alive and writing in our generation. He has suffered in his own flesh with our generation. He is both of us and with us. Born to a working-class French Colonial family in 1913 he knew none of the *douceurs de la vie* which held the memory in the first World War; while in the second he took an active part in the French Resistance movement and after the Liberation edited the periodical *Combat*. His novels—*L'Étranger* (1942) and *La Peste* (1947)—are not so much works of imaginative creation as fictional records of the events of our time. His plays—*Le Malentendu* (1943), *Caligula* (1945), *L'État de siège* (1948), *Les Justes* (1950)—are studies or allegories of moral and political collapse in its various and varying moods. Like *Actuelles*, a collection of his current writing from 1944 to 1948, both novels and plays are testimonies of the anxieties through which our generation has passed.

Thus the epithet Contemporary would seem to be justified. I return then to the word Moralist and proceed to enquire what Camus has to tell us about the human condition. I shall start with a brief survey

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of the two novels and draw attention to a remarkable shift of attitude between them. I shall then turn to the commentary provided by the essays (*Le Mythe de Sisyphe*; *Actuelles*), watching the ground broadening out in various literary and ethical theses; and conclude with a consideration of the historical and philosophical analysis given in the last major work, *L'Homme révolté*. A general echo will be offered from the plays. I should perhaps say that I shall treat all this body of writing not in the context of the general development of French letters or in the light of local literary controversy, but in itself as comprising documents of general and urgent interest. The special background—Occupation; Resistance; Liberation—is not that of this country, and there are important differences of emphasis common to the whole Continental tradition. Yet the movement of thought will be found, I think, both intelligible and valuable; and its study will help us to understand some of the pressing problems of our neighbours.

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L'Étranger is the story of a young clerk who loses his mother; attends her funeral; returns to the office; takes out a girl or two; goes on a visit to a friend; joins in an obscure dispute; lets off a gun; kills a man; is tried and condemned to death. Its studied brittleness of style, which in its paratactic simplicity reminds one of Damon Runyon's, reflects a studied brittleness of action; if action there can be said to be. For there is no real action. Things happen, and not very interesting things at that. Incident attaches itself to incident, triviality to triviality. A cigarette is taken out and smoked; or put back. The Stranger himself is not a hero, hardly even a subject. He is the person to whom what happens happens. But he should not be called a person. He has hardly even a name. He is an anonymous nobody who happens casually to be involved in this and that casual and anonymous happening.

The point is not that we are slaves to a brute necessity of nature. There is no nature or brute necessity to be enslaved to. Everything is indifferent. No moral is drawn nor is there one to be drawn. There is no room for a moral. He did this. He might just as well have done that. This and that are equally unimportant. We search for a meaning, but as we read and ponder it is borne upon us that there is no meaning; and that is the only meaning. The individual who is the Stranger is a purposeless atom moved about in a purposeless void. Mere life, like mere death, is not even confusion. It is emptiness.

But let us make a further, and different, attempt. Let us watch life, not in an individual but in a community, a community secluded for experimental purposes and observed as it acts and develops from

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within. Suppose a society cut off from the rest of humankind, say a city smitten with plague. Here is life, the life of a community, self-contained and self-enclosed. Let us see how it will behave. Will it too be just neutral, an agglomeration of particles blown aimlessly in the void; or will there emerge what are called virtues and vices, good and evil, right and wrong?

This study of a closed society under the stress of vital danger forms the subject of Camus' second novel, *La Peste*. Its effect is to give the lie to the neutralism of *L'Étranger*. The void takes shape; the particles assume direction. True, evil appears as well as good, but evil is better than emptiness; and where there is evil, even much evil, there is also good, in however slight a degree. Human tenderness is good; happiness is good; the science of medicine—that is, helping through knowledge—is good. The great evil is ignorance and the brute disregard for human feeling which stems from ignorance. It is a stoical picture, but it contains at least something which is akin to the traditional lineaments of man so strikingly absent from the picture given in *L'Étranger*; and it is worthy of note that, in the lists of Camus' works, this novel is registered not as a story (*récit*) but as a chronicle (*chronique*).

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The volume of essays entitled *Le Mythe de Sisyphe*, appeared in 1942, the year of the publication of the first novel, *L'Étranger*. Like the play *Le Malentendu* (of 1943), a sombre account of the murder, by a mother and daughter, of a returned but unrecognized prodigal son, it would seem to spring from the same background and the same assumptions as *L'Étranger*. Considering the facts of the time, it is not a matter for surprise that it attracted great attention. Its opening words form a striking challenge: "There is only one really serious philosophical problem, the problem of suicide. To judge that life is worth, or that it is not worth, the trouble of being lived, is to reply to the fundamental question of philosophy. The rest—whether the world has three dimensions, whether the mind has nine categories or twelve—all that comes afterwards."

We should observe the title of this first section of these essays. It is called An Absurd Argument; just as the second section is entitled Man the Absurd, and the third Creation and Absurdity. The word Absurd pursues us throughout. It is the pivot around which the whole book revolves; and indeed not this book of Camus alone.

I find, for example, Pierre Loti quoted¹ as having written in 1917: "Since we have now gained the absolute certitude that we shall never

¹ By M. Robert de Traz in his *Pierre Loti*, Hachette, 1948, p. 153.

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understand, and that we are being brought up more and more against the Terrible and Absurd (both with capital letters!) facing us in the shadows . . . ”

The Absurd, then (and we hear much of it in recent French writing), is the latest shape assumed by the ancient *Vanitas Vanitatum*; and it is perhaps characteristic of the peculiar quality attributed traditionally to the French genius that the new name would seem to derive from the vocabulary of logic. But to say that the world is “absurd” does not mean that an argument *about* the world leads to a contradiction and is therefore false. It means that the world as such is recognized by us as offering no ground for any argument at all. Argument rests on the assumption of the common validity of thought processes and the intelligibility of the events argued about; but belief in valid thinking has long been sapped by the enquiries of psychologists, belief in intelligibility by ordinary common sense. Thus the world, emptied of both intelligence and intelligibility, becomes indeed an empty waste. It is in fact the futility depicted in the narration of *L'Étranger* and symbolized by the endless pushing up by Sisyphus of a stone which is endlessly falling down.

But men cannot rest in the idea of an empty world, nor does the idea survive the test of fact. The world of *L'Étranger* gives way to the world of *La Peste*, and the path is marked by Camus' occasional writings.

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For Camus is not only a novelist and playwright and philosophical essayist. He is also a working journalist, expressing himself from day to day on the urgent questions of current life. It is a selection of this professional (and kindred) work during the first years of the Liberation which makes up the contents of *Actuelles* (1950), and we are thus enabled to understand in which direction, and under what influences, his thought was moving during those years of moral and political crisis.

One point stands out. Camus became intensely conscious of the nature of his duty as a writer, and indeed of the function of writers in general.

On this question there had been a good deal of discussion in French literary circles. The old answers: to amuse, to instruct, to distract, to refresh; to depict another world more satisfying than this; to “make people real to themselves by words”; to “turn a perfect sentence”; to “create the sentence in itself beautiful: multitudinous seas; daffodils that come before the swallow dares”; to “set a chime of words tinkling in the minds of a few fastidious people”—these and the like were rejected as the “delicate superfluities” of a softer age. Modern

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conditions, we were assured, need sterner stuff. Writers were asked, nay, commanded, to plunge into affairs; to take a stand and to fight for that stand; in a word, to "commit" themselves.

Camus' own answer is "to testify and raise a voice"; but he does not specify the subject of the testimony or the cause for which the voice is to be raised. Nor indeed could he. For writers are to "testify to," that is, "be witnesses for, Freedom"; and the right they should testify to and defend above all others is the right of other people not to be of their opinion. It is ridiculous to tell a writer to "commit" himself. In a sense the call is harmless but superfluous. Who is there in our time, or for that matter in any time, who is not committed? To be alive is in itself commitment! But the call to commitment in the accepted sense is not only not harmless; it is directly pernicious. In practice it means, and was intended to mean, taking sides as a partisan, that is, accepting, and propounding eternally, one final and immutable set of ideas. Ideologies are by their nature exclusive. They are coldly and starkly exigent. The ideologist is an ever-sounding tom-tom, the raucous juke-box of a dictated monologue.

Camus' plea is for not a monologue but a dialogue. A dialogue involves at least one other person, and its method is not intimidation but persuasion. It aims at unity, but a unity of agreement, not a totality of suppression. Commitment means adherence to the one end which is held to justify the use of any means. It is self-enslavement to the omniscient planners who are so sure that they have Truth that they see their duty in sacrificing to it the last drop both of their own and of other people's blood.

But Camus asks whether any man can ever be as sure as all that; and he proclaims his own allegiance to the party of those who know that they are sometimes wrong. And even if men are so sure, does their sureness give them the right to spill blood? He returns again and again to this question. As in the plays *Le Malentendu* and *Caligula* so here the word "murder" forms a grim and sullen undertone to the whole. For Camus sees humanity at the cross-roads, and on the signpost is the challenge: "Shalt thou, or shalt thou not, kill?"

It should be noted that the plea, although for peace, is not for what is generally called pacifism. Camus fought in the Resistance, and no Resistance fighter could agree that there are not occasions when violence has to be met by violence. His point is rather that in our time the use of violence has become a recognized mode of public action, both usual and accepted as legitimate. *Crimes* of violence there have been always. It is only in our time that they have become legal. Current ways of thought have turned the murderer into a judge, and judges into murderers. Murder as a means, terror as an instrument of policy—these are the accompaniments and consequences of blind faith. Camus does not say so here, but he would seem to be able to

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subscribe whole-heartedly to the sober view that the curse of the world is the idealist.

Be that as it may, Camus sees one thing clearly. The arrogation by human beings, because of an alleged Truth which is in them, of the right to take life, is a primary concern. On the view we take of it depends the nature of our civilization.

It is a significant shift from *Le Mythe de Sisyphe*. The *Mythe* debates the problem of suicide and declares that the principal point for decision is whether life is or is not worth the trouble of living for the individual who, if he thinks it is not and if he is not persuaded to the contrary by Camus' somewhat tenuous reasoning, may incline to kill himself. Camus asks now not whether or no a man has a right to kill himself but whether or no a man has a right to kill others. He has not forgotten the individual but he is concerned with the duty of society to allow the individual the right to his own mind. As he puts it in his own terminology: "The programme for tomorrow is the City of the Dialogue."

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The other kind of city, the City of the Monologue, Camus has depicted already. It is the theme of *Caligula*, a play written earlier but first performed in 1945. Here we are shown the Possessor of Truth in control. The scene opens on a Rome agitated by the absence of the Emperor. He had disappeared for three days. When he returns, his familiar is asked whether Caligula had told him where he had been. He replies: "I am not his confidant. I am his audience. That is far wiser. As all the world knows, Caligula is an idealist. He pursues his idea and that is all. Where it will take him, no one can foresee."

The Idealist on the Throne displays all the characteristics of other idealists, together with the power to exercise them in action. He has a passion for Truth. He suffers no lies or deceit around him. He creates the solitude of his own righteousness. He feels his will as completely free. He recognizes no limit or restraint. Anything in his way must be removed. He scorns the world and finds its conditions insupportable. His god is logic, the implacable logic which grinds human lives into powder; his happiness the "limitless joy of an assassin who needs never fear retribution!" Caligula is not a fool and he is not repulsive: a charming scene shows his effortless winning of the heart of a young artist whose father he has had killed. Nor is he, in the ordinary sense, insane. He is simply a mortal who has taken upon himself the nature and attributes of deity. He is mad with the madness of a Chestertonian world-reformer ready to destroy the whole of creation in order to assert his own idea. He is one of those "lovers of perfection" who, in Leo XIIth's phrase, "would, if they were allowed, pull the

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world upside down." He kills without cause. He is not bound by causes. He is naked power for which everything is indifferent. It takes a poet to point out to him that life and happiness are not identical with logic, and that some actions are in themselves better than others. Sanity is preferable to consistency.

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We may now take up the play, or rather the "morality" (in the French it is called a "spectacle"), *L'État de siège* (1948), which resumes, with one additional note, all that has gone before. The preface tells us of its historical connexion with the second novel, *La Peste*; but now the story of the plague has become a myth explicitly, and what was implicit in the novel is brought to full light. The plague in person takes command in a city in Spain, and we are shown all the indignities of an imposed "new order": the proscriptions, the delations, the censorship, the breaking of the spirit by omniscient and omnifarious regimentation. Cowardice and cruelty and arrogance combine with system and the pursuit of an idea to produce government by decree and food cards. Private life ceases; love and laughter become crimes; unregulated death not permissible. The affairs of everyday living are not allowed to run wild but are made a matter of statistics and certificates. The new order abhors unreason. Every contingency is met by filling up forms.

But—and here the note of hope is struck—the régime falls. The perfect machine makes mistakes. The wind changes and freshness comes from the sea. The discovery is made that if only one man overcomes his fear, the machine will jam. So with the cry: "Long live death; we are not afraid," redemption begins.

For death, and death-dealing, is not the way. As is remarked in the play *Les Justes*, a study of Russian terrorism in the time of the Czars: "If death is the only solution we have to offer, we have gone wrong." The man who could have thrown the bomb refrained from throwing it because he caught sight of two children in the carriage of the Grand Duke he was about to assassinate; and when a more fully-fashioned comrade says afterwards in protest that if only they had the courage to kill children they would become masters of the world, he is met with the retort: "Aye, and be hated by all mankind."

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The writer most akin to Camus I find in recent English literature is the late George Orwell. Both Camus and Orwell write clearly, and both Camus and Orwell know clearly the infamous thing to be destroyed. "Every line of serious work which I have written since

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1936," says Orwell, "has been written, directly or indirectly, *against* totalitarianism and *for* democratic socialism, as I understand it. It seems to me nonsense, in a period like our own, to think that one can avoid writing of such subjects." Or again, in an essay reprinted in the same collection (*England, Your England*): "This is a political age. War, fascism, concentration camps, rubber truncheons, atomic bombs, etc., are what we daily think about." So Orwell, in 1948. Says Camus, in the same year, somewhat more dramatically: "The seventeenth century was the century of mathematics; the eighteenth of the physical sciences; the nineteenth of biology. Our century, the twentieth, is the century of fear" (*Actuelles*, p. 141); and he proceeds to explain the new turn in the human scene whereby the human voice and the human appeal has lost its power, and men no longer speak or understand the language of humanity: "We have seen lying and degrading and killing and deporting and torturing; and every time it was not possible to persuade those who were doing it, not to do it, because they were sure of themselves and because one cannot persuade an abstraction, that is to say, the representative of an ideology . . . We live in terror because persuasion is no longer possible. . . ." (*ib.* 142-3).

In this recognition of the nature of the amorality of our time Orwell and Camus speak with one voice. But Camus goes deeper than Orwell in that he has tried to dig down into its historical origins and unravel its universal character. Orwell's intense vision was of the present and he saw it clearly, so clearly, however, as to make him over-sharpen the issues and to invite the censure of exaggeration. The present is manifest to him in so vivid a manner as to swallow up all past and future in an emphatic and terrifying Now. Camus too felt the present, but for him it is rooted in historical conditions which require and repay study. In his view our situation is neither a momentary lapse nor an all-engulfing present. It was prefigured long ago and is not therefore out-of-the-way or accidental; but at the same time our own experience suffices to show that the collapse is not total.

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This is the theme of *L'Homme révolté* (1951), Camus' major work to date. It opens with an argument which in the sphere of morals recalls that of Descartes in the sphere of metaphysics. Descartes, it will be remembered, faced with extreme scepticism, by-passed it by pointing out that in the very act of disbelief there is involved the existence of certitude. Camus, faced with the nihilism deduced from the facts of human misery, by-passes it by pointing out that, in the very act of revolt engendered by extreme misery, there is affirmed the existence of human value. For revolt is not a bare rejection of external oppres-

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sion. It is an affirmation of right. And the right affirmed is a universal right. It is based on the primal recognition of a limit to suffering. The slave turns finally against the oppressor but the significant thing is not that. The significant thing is that in so turning he discovers something of value within himself which is identical with something of value within other men. He reveals, and is prepared to fight for, universal Man who is one and the same in himself and in all men. Thus his revolt is not for himself as an isolated individual. It is for the humanity outraged both in himself and in all others. In the world of particular fact, a world of oppression and misery, the act of revolt uncovers universal value.

It is this discovery, the discovery of the universal significance of revolt, which sets the scene of this book of Camus and which makes it so remarkable an achievement. I can best illustrate its character, perhaps, by contrasting a passage of Camus with a passage from the report of a newspaper correspondent on a visit to a concentration camp immediately after the Liberation:

It was not torture which had killed the prisoners [writes the correspondent, Mr. Alan Moorehead]. It was sheer neglect. The sheer indifference . . . One began to see that the most terrible thing on earth is not positive destruction nor the perverse desire to hurt and destroy. The worst thing that can happen to you is for the master to say: "I do not care about you any more. I am indifferent." Whether you washed or ate or died—none of this was of any consequence any more because you as a person had no value. You were a slug on the ground, to be crushed or not to be crushed, it made no difference.

(ALAN MOOREHEAD, "Belsen"; reprinted in *The Golden Horizon*, 1953, p. 109.)

So far Mr. Moorehead. Now for Camus:

Facing his master, the slave is not concerned to deny the master's existence. He denies him as master. He denies that the master has the right to deny him, the slave, as a demand [upon himself]. The master forfeits his position in the exact proportion as he does not respond to a demand which he neglects. If men cannot refer themselves to a common value, then man is incomprehensible to man. The rebel demands that this value be clearly recognized in himself because he suspects, or knows, that, without this principle, disorder and crime would reign over the world. The movement of revolt appears in him as a claim for clearness and unity. The most elementary rebellion expresses, paradoxically, the aspiration to an order."

(*Homme révolté*, pp. 39—40.)

The difference between these two passages is illuminating. They are compatible with one another and reinforce one another, but the second represents a further, and a higher, stage than the first. The first states the plain fact and accepts it; the second goes beyond that fact and proclaims its transcendence. Moorehead is at the end of his spiritual resources. All is dark. He can see no further. The master no longer cares and the slave perishes. It is the master's indifference

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which counts, and kills. Not so for Camus. For him a time comes when even the uncared-for slave revolts; and the very act of revolt reveals, and opens, a door which leads out from individualistic pessimism. For when acquiescence gives way to revolt, the revolt is no longer, as was the acquiescence, merely personal. Or rather, perhaps, because it is personal in the true sense, it proclaims the common value of all persons in their one humanity, the common value of masters and slaves alike. Camus has travelled far; and we can see now the significance of the shift in attitude from *L'Étranger* to *La Peste*. The path is a decisive one, and it is the path described by Camus himself elsewhere, in his account of the Artist in Prison, Oscar Wilde (*Encounter*, March 1954), as that which "led him from the art of the drawing-room, where everyone listens only to the echo of his own voice, to the art of the prison, where every cell cries out with the same cry of agony as the man murdered by his fellows."

"Prison," "agony," "murder"—it is a melancholy subject and we are all rather tired of it. But as Moorehead remarks at the close of the article I have just quoted, that is just the danger, that we should tire and forget: "The physical evidence of all those horrible places will soon have been wiped out. Only the mental danger remains. The danger of indifference." Camus is not indifferent nor does he forget; and he manages to draw from his memories not despair but confidence and hope. True, there is misery. But misery brings revolt, and revolt is not bare negation. It is the positive uprising of man for man, of man for all men. It is the revelation to man himself, through the primal verity of his own actions, of the value which underlies all human existence.

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Yet we must beware of idealizing revolt. Revolt has another side, a nasty side. It becomes tainted with the vileness it combats and emerges as terroristic messianism.

The characteristic marks of this perversion are a nostalgia for a terrestrial paradise and a ruthless cruelty in taking steps to its realization. Terroristic messianism takes the moulds of religion without its restraint, usurping the seat of the God it has dethroned while forgetting that that seat was one of mercy. Its proclaimed aims are justice and life and truth, but these are to appear only at the end of days. In the interim, murder and lying and *in*justice are natural and constitute permitted tools. The messianist lives in a world of abstractions. He has no warmth in his soul. At his best he is a Robespierre—Camus analyses powerfully the (to us) less familiar case of Saint-Just—the deadly personification of all that is logical and incorruptible and inhumane.

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Camus himself elaborates the analysis on the historical side. He starts, as in duty bound, with the "Marquis" de Sade, and draws some pertinent illustrations from the Russian anarchists. For interpretation and running commentary he relies on certain well-known figures from the novels of Dostoevsky. And indeed, as one re-reads such a book as *The Possessed*, one understands why its truer English title, as it is given by its latest translator, is, in the strictly descriptive sense, *The Devils*.

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Thus Revolt is to be distinguished from its perversion which we may call Revolution. Revolt is an affirmation, within the condition of man, of a limit to human misery. Revolution, affirming no more than the misery, sees its only way in negating the condition of man. Revolt sets out from what we are, and seeks to develop and correct it; Revolution, in its straining to make us something other than what we are, can do nothing but destroy what is. Revolt looks to a form of society in which men will return to, and work in, a natural grouping. Revolution knows nothing either of nature or of grouping and flies to Caesarism and the deification of history. But nature exists, and human nature exists, and both nature and human nature are not destructive but creative.

It is in Art that Camus, like other French thinkers of our time, finds the key to a better way. Art, like Revolt, is both acceptance of the world and the attempt at its correction. Art stylizes and unifies; binds the disparate and heterogeneous; disciplines, re-fashions, improves. It gives form and thus makes anew. So too does life. Life for Camus is an Art; and the matter on which it impresses form is the human condition, as may indeed be seen from the art of the novel on which Camus offers some admirable paragraphs.

The classical ear will catch the echo at once; and what Camus somewhat unguardedly, in view of its history, appeals to under the name of Syndicalism and which we might perhaps call Gild Socialism, would be better expressed in terms of the "koinonia" of the *Politics*. But I suppose Camus would say, and with truth, that the doctrine of "koinonia" too leads to the "Servile State" if individual effort is forgotten. The root of the matter lies for Camus in the self-discovery by the individual that his claim is not for total liberty. Only a Caligula can talk of total liberty. There is in each of us a consciousness of limit, a limit which we cannot overstep without contradicting our nature.

This consciousness of limit excludes absolutism of whatever kind. As we have noticed before, Camus claims adhesion to the party—if there be indeed enough of them to form a party—of those who know

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that they may be mistaken. Intelligence, he remarks wisely, is the faculty of *not* pushing our ideas to extremes. There is a German proverb to the effect that he who says A must say B; but the proverb is one not of revolt but of Revolution. It is precisely because, if one says A, there is no necessity to say B, that sensible people are not bound to Caesarism.

Thus we rest in the position that there is a limit in all things, and there is a limit restraining the relations between man and man. For the limit we recognize in our own selves we recognize to exist in others, so that we see in them too, just as in ourselves, a limit beyond which they may not be pushed. We dare not do unto others what we would not others do unto us.

Thus Camus, out of the depths of the despair of our time and with a full knowledge of its spiritual chaos; a knowledge not theoretical or verbal but ground out of the ever-present agony of the torturings and the shootings and the concentration camps in the shadow of which he and his friends passed their everyday existence for many weary years—Camus would seem to have created (possibly in his own despite) what has been wanted so urgently and so long but has been so infrequently produced, a sustained and reasoned apology for Liberalism.

II

Nor is this all. Camus would seem to be not only a Liberal. He would seem to be also a Humanist. A Humanist is a man who asserts, and is prepared to draw the consequences from, the existence of a general human nature, the existence, that is, not only of *homines* but of *humanitas*. As we have seen, it is this path, the path from *homines* to *humanitas*, that Camus has so interestingly trod.

We may retrace the successive points of this progress. The first novel, *L'Étranger*, with the first play, *Le Malentendu*, and the first serious volume of essays, *Le Mythe de Sisyphe*, all study, from various aspects and in various situations, the atomic individual. Such an entity, we learn, is completely neutral. It knows no values and no code. Love, hate, kindness, cruelty, pity, murder—it sees them all with an indifferent eye. Crime becomes a misunderstanding, suicide a subject for debate. The lighting of a cigarette and the murder of a son by sister and mother are actions of equal weightlessness. There is no such thing as common feeling; and so the only arbitrament between the isolated individuals is that of an all-levelling logic backed by an all-destroying force. The grand total is given in the play *Caligula*, the picture of the idealist in power.

But men are not isolated atoms, and the proof is in the facts of experience. Men are thrown together and the spark is struck; or they

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are oppressed and revolt. The hand of circumstance may weigh so heavily as to overpass, and thus to manifest, the limit of human endurance, a limit which holds for others as well as for ourselves and so declares the common nature of us all. Through Revolt man recognizes himself for what he is, the bearer of a universal humanity: "I revolt, hence Man is."

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And with that, in admiration and gratitude, I leave Camus and his account of the human condition. I have viewed him as a moralist and even so I have treated him, I fear, summarily. I have made no mention of the rich artistry or the broad context of his work, nor of the carefulness of its planning and elaboration. I have stripped it to its bare bones, making harsh distinctions where I should, perhaps, have shown transitions, and ignoring all subtlety and grace. Yet even under these limitations and at this cost I hope that I have given some suggestion of his measure.

I do not know whether the experts see in his novels a lasting contribution to literature, or whether his plays and kindred literary ventures give him title to permanent fame. Possibly not; though I should have thought that such literary skill, harnessed to such clear understanding and such passionate indignation, would have produced work of first importance. That is as may be; but, literary judgements apart, Camus seems to me, because of the seriousness of the problems he treats and the vividness and genuineness with which he treats them, to touch greatness. He stands firm in the tradition of European thought.

British philosophy in our day has been said to have become a little less than a snort, a little more than a sneeze. If this is true, it would seem to be at the least a pity, at the most, like all abdication, a tragedy. For the problems are there, particularly in the human sphere we have been discussing, however the professionals may view them. The matter of Ethics remains, as ever, what we do with our lives; that of Politics, especially in our time, what life does with us. It is because the world of modern French letters finds a real concern in Ethics and Politics that it commands, and arrests, and deserves, our attention. The authentic voice is there.

Not but what it might not be somewhere else too.